

Stack M — Game Length Cut

Bundled change set. Session 25 (2026-06-21). Six simultaneous changes — intentional methodology deviation per Principle 7 (“while core identity is unsettled, prefer fundamental shifts over variable tweaking”).

1 SECTION Introduction

(GAME NAME) is a 2-player abstract-tactical board game. There is no luck — no dice, no hidden information. Every decision is made with full knowledge of the board.

What you command: Each player leads an army of Guards and Champions, all serving a King. Guards are fast, Champions carry powerful skills. Your King is the most important piece on the board — and the target.

How you win: Capture the opponent's King. The game ends immediately when a King is removed.

How a game flows: Players alternate turns. On your turn you first move your pieces (and attack), then activate skills. Piece capture, skill combos, and board control build toward the moment you threaten — and take — the enemy King.

2 SECTION Simple Overview

A surface-level map of every system. No edge cases — just what each thing does.

Rounds and turns: The game is played in Rounds. Each Round, P1 takes a full turn, then P2. A turn has two phases: Move Phase, then Skill Phase.

Move Phase: You have 2 actions. Spend one to move a piece up to its speed. Each piece can only be moved once per phase.

Move-Attack: Instead of moving into empty space, spend an action to move your piece onto an enemy tile. The enemy takes 1 damage.

Health: Every piece has 2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed. Taking 1 damage moves a piece one step along that track. Injured is purely an HP-tracker — pieces operate at full speed and Range.

Armor: A piece can hold up to 2 Armor. Each point absorbs 1 incoming damage **before** HP is affected, then is destroyed.

Skill Phase: You have actions (starting at 2 per turn). Spend one action + Money to activate an equipped skill on one of your Champions or King.

Money: Your currency. You earn it automatically each turn (starting at +2/turn, scaling up over time). Skills cost Money.

Skills and Path: Skills travel in a straight line from the caster (like a chess Queen). That path is blocked by any piece in the way. Most skills have a default range of 2 tiles.

Bodyguard: When a Champion or King is hit by a Move-Attack, you can choose to have an adjacent Guard take the hit instead.

Skill Drafting: Before the game, players alternate picking skills from a shared pool and assigning them to their Champions and King. Each piece gets 2 skills.

Progression: As the game goes on, your Money income and the number of actions in your Skill Phase both grow — late-game turns are more powerful because you can cast more skills.

For full rules and edge cases, read the sections below.

3 SECTION Goal

Capture the opponent's **King**. The game ends immediately when a King is removed from the board.

4 SECTION Components

Per player: 1 King · 5 Champions · 6 Guards

Champions and the King have 2 Equip Slots each. Skills are equipped into these slots. Guards have no Equip Slots and carry no skills.

Shared (Prototype): 10x10 grid board · Skill cards · Injured markers · Armor pieces

5 SECTION Skill Drafting

- Lay out all available skills face-up as a shared pool.
- Alternating draft: P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King → P2 picks 2 skills and assigns freely → repeat.
- Continue until all 5 Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills.
- Both players draft from the same pool. Duplicates are allowed.

6 SECTION Setup

- **Board:** Use the **8×8 grid**.
- **First player:** Flip a coin (or decide verbally).
- **Piece placement:** Fixed layout — players do not choose tiles.
 - Back row (row 1/8): The King stands in the middle of the row, **offset so the two Kings are not directly opposite each other**. On one side of the King stand **2 Champions**; on the other side stand **3 Champions**. (Both players use the same layout, but each chooses independently which side gets 2 and which gets 3 — mirror or stagger as needed so the Kings are not on the same file.)
 - Second row (row 2/7): One Guard directly in front of each Champion **and** one Guard directly in front of the King — **6 Guards total**.
- **Skill Draft:** Alternating picks. P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King, then P2. Repeat until both Equip Slots on every Champion and King are filled (12 skills per player). Duplicates allowed.
- **Starting Money:** Each player starts with **6 Money**.
- P1 begins Round 1.

7 SECTION Round Structure

A **Round** = P1's Turn + P2's Turn.

At the **start of each player's turn** (before they do anything), that player collects their Money income.
(Exception: Round 1 — players begin with their starting Money and collect nothing before their first turn.)

8 SECTION Turn Structure

Each **Turn** has two phases, in order:

- **Move Phase** — spend actions to move pieces (and attack).
- **Skill Phase** — spend actions to activate skills.

You may use 0 actions in either phase.

9 SECTION Move Phase

You have **2 actions** per turn. Spend 1 action to move one piece — either **into empty space** (normal movement) or **into an enemy tile** (a Move-Attack — see next section). **Each piece may only be moved once per Move Phase.**

Piece	Normal speed	Injured speed
Guard	2 tiles	1 tile
Champion / King	1 tile	1 tile

Free pathing: A piece may move in any direction — horizontal, vertical, diagonal — taking any route up to its speed in tiles. The route does not have to be a straight line.

Pieces block movement: A moving piece cannot pass through any other piece, ally or opponent.

- *Exception:* A piece may go around a blocking piece if total tiles moved stays within speed (e.g. a Guard using 2 diagonal moves to go around a piece directly in the way).

10 SECTION Move-Attack

A **Move-Attack** is a Move that ends on an enemy tile. Spend 1 action to move your piece **onto a tile occupied by an enemy piece.**

- Deal **1 damage** to the enemy.
- **If the enemy is removed:** your piece occupies the tile (the attack consumed the move; remaining unused movement tiles do not carry over).
- **If the enemy survives** (Armor absorbed the damage): your piece **stops on the tile immediately before the target.** This applies to **every** attacker — a Guard with speed 2 ends up having moved only 1 tile; a Champion or King with speed 1 does not move at all. Either way the damage is dealt. (*If multiple paths reach the target, you choose which one — important for the Bodyguard Rule.*)

You may attack with one action and move a different piece with the other action in the same turn.

Move-Attacks are how pieces deal damage with movement alone. Skills — activated in the Skill Phase — are the other way pieces affect each other, and use different rules (Path, Range, Money).

11 SECTION Bodyguard Rule

When you make a **Move-Attack** against an opponent's Champion or King, the defender may choose to have a Guard intercept — **if a friendly Guard is on a tile adjacent to both the tile immediately before the target (along the attack path) and the defending piece.**

Interception:

- Defender announces a Guard to intercept.
- The Guard takes the damage instead of the original target.
- The attacker moves **1 tile** toward the target (stops on the tile immediately before the target).

Interception is optional. The defender may decline even if a Guard is eligible and can select which guard should take the damage if multiple Guards are eligible.

Only Move-Attacks can be intercepted. Skills always hit directly.

12 SECTION ⚡ CHANGED: Multi-Champion Combo Bonus

Each enemy piece has a **combo counter** (starts at 0, resets at the end of your turn).

Triggers that tick the counter (when a **new Champion** — one that didn't already increment this counter this turn — performs one of these on the target):

- A **Strike skill** that hits the target.
- A **Movement-causing skill** that moves the target (e.g.  **Tempest**'s push,  **Blast**,  **Shove**,  **Hook**'s pull,  **Swap** when it relocates an enemy).

Bonus damage: Any skill — Strike **or** movement-causing — that affects a target with a combo counter > 0 deals **+counter damage** to that target. This means even pure movement skills become a damage vector once the counter is built up.

What doesn't count: Move-Attacks. Pure buffs ( **Charge**,  **Focus**,  **Plate**). Pure heals. Self-movement ( **Dash**,  **Retreat**). Pushing a friendly piece.

Stacks with  **Charge** as before. **A single skill that both hits and moves the target ticks the counter only once** (both effects from the same skill collapse into one increment, and bonus damage is applied once).

13 SECTION Skill Phase

You have **2 actions** per turn (at the start (see Progression)).

Spend 1 action to activate one equipped skill on one of your Champions or King:

- Announce the skill and the target.
- Pay the skill's Money cost.
- Apply the skill's effect.

The same Champion can activate multiple skills (also the same one) in one turn if you have actions remaining.

14 SECTION Skill System

Path: Skills travel in a **straight line** (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal) from the caster, like a chess Queen.

Blocking: The Path is blocked by **all pieces** — ally and opponent alike. The skill cannot reach past the first piece in its path.

Range: The distance in tiles along the Path from caster to target. Range is measured as:

- Range 0 = self (caster's own tile)
- Range 1 = adjacent tile along the Path
- Range 2 = 2 tiles away along the Path (etc.)

Default Range = 2. Unless a skill explicitly names "self" or "adjacent" in its effect text. A skill with a Range modifier (e.g. "Range -1") is still a Range 2 skill with a modifier applied — it is not treated as adjacent or self.

Self vs. adjacent: "Self" skills (Range 0) target only the caster — they cannot target adjacent pieces by default. "Adjacent" skills (Range 1) target only neighbouring pieces — they cannot target the caster, even with a Range buff. Range buffs (e.g.  Focus) shift the targeting window outward. A Range buff on a Self skill **extends** its reach: Self +  Focus → Range 1. Range buffs do not collapse Adjacent skills inward toward Self.

Skills that move pieces do not deal damage. Movement-via-skill (, , ) does not count as a Move-Attack and deals no damage on arrival — you are instead stopped from moving the piece further in that direction. (Exception: bonus damage from the Combo Bonus still applies.)

A Champion may use its skills multiple times in the same turn if actions are available — including the same skill twice.

All skills cost 1 action unless noted otherwise.

15 SECTION Money

Starting Money: 6 per player.

Money income is collected at the **start of each player's own turn**:

Round	Income per player turn
1	0 (starting Money only)
2-4	+2
5-9	+3
10-14	+4
15+	+5 (+1 every 5 rounds)

No Money cap.

16 SECTION Progression

Round	Actions per Skill Phase
1-10	2
11-20	3
21-30	4
31+	5 (+1 every 10 rounds)

17 SECTION ⚡ CHANGED: Health & Armor

Every piece has **2 HP**: Normal → Injured → Removed. There are no debuffs at any HP state — Injured is just a marker showing the piece is one hit from death.

Armor: Max 2 per piece. Each point absorbs 1 damage **before** HP is affected, then is destroyed.

18 SECTION Skill Reference

	Cat.	Name	Cost	Effect
	Strike	Lance	2	Target within Range-1 takes 1 damage
	Strike	Hook	3	Target takes 1 damage, pulled 1 tile toward caster along the Path
	Strike	Break	2	Remove 1 Armor from target. <i>(Note: does not deal "HP-Damage" unless boosted by Charge)</i>
	Strike	Steal	4	Target takes 1 damage. Steal 1 Money from opponent.
	Strike	Tempest	4	Target takes 1 damage. All pieces adjacent to the target are pushed 1 tile away from the target. The attacker/caster is not affected.
	Shield	Shield	2	Self: gain +1 Armor
	Shield	Heal	3	Remove Injured from one adjacent ally
	Shield	Plate	3	Adjacent ally gains +1 Armor
	Move	Dash	3	Self: move up to 2 tiles along the Path
	Move	Blast	2	Push target enemy 1 tile directly away from caster
	Move	Shove	3	Push target enemy 1 tile in any direction (caster chooses). Range+1.
	Move	Swap	4	Swap position with an allied piece. Requires unobstructed Path.
	Move	Retreat	4	Self: move along the Path to land adjacent to one of your Guards. Range+1.
	Mystic	Focus	1	The next skill used by any of your pieces this turn gains +1 Range. <i>(Note: can boost self and adjacent skills — Range 0 → 1, Range 1 → 2.)</i> Move skills: the caster chooses, when activating the Move skill, whether the +1 applies to its activation range (how far the skill can target) or its effect range (how far it moves/pushes). Not both.
	Mystic	Charge	3	One Strike skill used by any of your pieces this turn deals +1 damage.

19 SECTION Quick Reference

Concept	Rule
Movement	Free pathing, ≤ speed in tiles, cannot pass through pieces. Each piece once per Move Phase.
Guard speed	Normal: 2 tiles. Injured: 2 tiles (no penalty).
Champion / King speed	1 tile (Normal or Injured).

Concept	Rule
Move-Attack	Move onto enemy tile (1 action). Deals 1 damage . Attacker stops before target if target survives.
Path	Straight line (Queen-style). Blocked by all pieces — ally and enemy.
Range	Default Range 2. Skills with "self" = Range 0. Skills with "adjacent" = Range 1. Range modifiers (e.g. Range-1) apply from default.
Injured Range penalty	None — Injured pieces operate at full speed and full Range.
Bodyguard	Move-Attacks on Champion/King only. Guard must be adjacent to both tile-before-target AND defender. Guard takes the hit. Defender chooses which eligible Guard intercepts.
Armor	Max 2 per piece. Each point absorbs 1 damage before HP, then is destroyed.
Health	2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed. 1 damage = one step. 2 damage = skip Injured, Removed instantly.
Money income	Collected at start of YOUR turn (not Round 1). Starts 6, then +2/+3/+4/+5 scaling.
Skill Phase actions	Start at 2/turn. Grow with Progression (Rounds 1-10: 2, 11-20: 3, 21-30: 4, 31+: 5).
Focus	+1 Range to next skill this turn. Can boost self (→ adjacent) and adjacent (→ Range 2) skills. On Move skills, caster chooses: activation range OR effect range.
Charge	+1 damage to one Strike skill this turn. Stacks with Combo Bonus.
Combo Bonus	Each enemy has a combo counter (resets end of your turn). A new Champion that hits with a Strike OR moves the target with a movement-causing skill ticks the counter +1. Any skill (Strike or movement-causing) that affects a target with counter > 0 deals +counter bonus damage . Move-Attacks excluded.
Board	8×8 grid . No terrain.
Draw conditions	None. Game ends only when a King is captured.
Steal cost	4 Money (both Modes).